STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

RECOGNITION THAT WORKS

How few feel recognised enough, who gives the recognition people remember, the five pillars of Gallup and Workhuman, what field experiments show, what recognition is worth, and a card for recognition that lands.

22% of US employees strongly agree that they get the right amount of recognition for the work they do.

GALLUP & WORKHUMAN, 2024

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Recognition costs little and most managers give it, yet it often misses. How much of it do people get, and from whom? What makes it work, and when does an award do more harm than good?

In 2024 only 22% of US employees strongly agreed that they get the right amount of recognition for their work; in Europe about one in three workers feel their efforts go unrewarded. The recognition people remember most often comes from their manager. Gallup and Workhuman describe five pillars of recognition that works. In field experiments a thank-you card and a symbolic award raised performance, while an attendance award lowered the efficiency of those who already came reliably. Gallup estimates what a business could gain if twice as many people heard praise each week.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

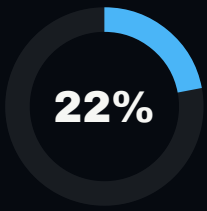
Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Enough recognition?

In spring 2024 Gallup and Workhuman asked employed adults in the United States about recognition at work. Only 22% strongly agreed that they get the right amount, the same share as in 2022.



strongly agree that they get the right amount of recognition for the work they do.

55%
receive no recognition at all, or recognition that meets none of the five pillars on page 5

11%
say someone at their workplace has ever asked how they like to be recognised

13%
strongly agree they know how others at work like to be recognised

OUR READING

Most of the 55% do hear a thank you. What is missing is recognition that fits the person and the work.

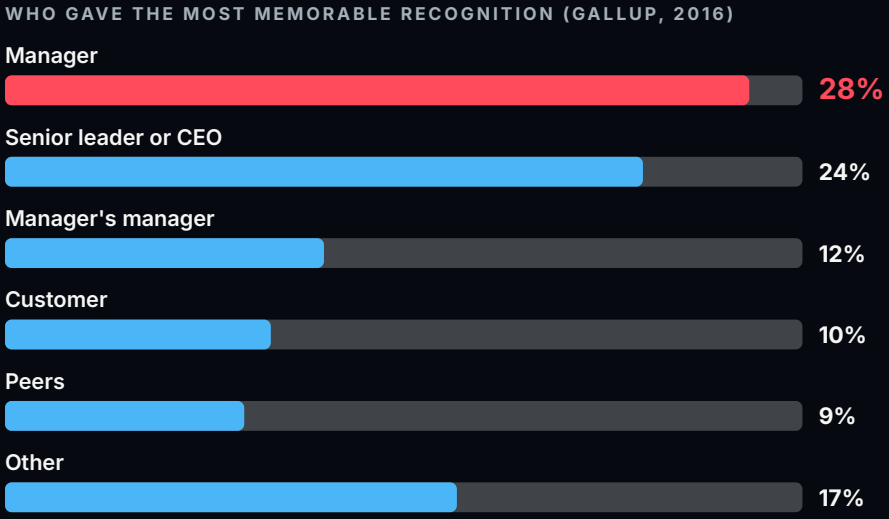
Source: Gallup & Workhuman, 2024

A US panel and self-reports; most results come from 4,439 people asked in April 2024. That the 22% is unchanged since 2022 is Gallup's statement in an article on the report.

THE NUMBERS

Who people remember

Gallup asked employees in a workplace survey to recall who gave them their most meaningful and memorable recognition. The answers, as Gallup published them in 2016:



Day to day the picture is different. In 2024, 46% of US employees said a peer recognises them at least a few times a month, and 38% said the same of a manager. In EU-OSHA's 2025 telephone survey of over 28,000 workers in Europe, about one in three felt their efforts go unrewarded.

OUR READING

Peers give recognition more often, but the manager's is the one people most often remember. A team needs both.

Sources: Gallup, 2016; Gallup & Workhuman, 2024; EU-OSHA, 2025

Gallup gives no sample or year for the question on memorable recognition; the six answers add up to 100%. Self-reports; for Albania we have no comparable figure.

THE MODEL

Five pillars of recognition

Gallup and Workhuman describe five pillars of strategic recognition. In their words, recognition has the most impact when it is fulfilling, authentic, personalised, equitable and embedded in the culture.

01	**Fulfilling**	the amount and the form fit the accomplishment
02	**Authentic**	it feels genuine, not like a box to tick
03	**Personalised**	it comes the way the person wants to be recognised
04	**Equitable**	it is about achievement, without favourites
05	**Embedded**	it is part of the values and of everyday work

In their 2024 report, employees whose recognition met even one pillar were 2.9 times as likely to be engaged as those whose recognition met none; with four or more, 9.0 times. Following 3,447 employees from 2022 to 2024, they found that the well-recognised, whose recognition met at least four pillars, were 45% less likely to have left two years later.

OUR READING

The pillars describe how recognition is received, not how often it is given. Whether it worked is decided by the person who gets it.

Sources: Gallup & Workhuman, 2024; Gallup & Workhuman, 2023

Correlations from a US panel, studied with Workhuman, a firm that sells recognition software. The 45% comes from following the same people over time, but it is still not proof of cause.

More in the essay Leading people without losing the person

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

A card helps, an award can harm

Surveys show correlations. Field experiments and a meta-analysis have tested recognition and rewards more directly, with effects in both directions.

≈ 12%
better performance when students could win a purely symbolic award (Kosfeld & Neckermann, 2011)

−8%
efficiency at daily tasks for workers with good attendance, after a laundry plant brought in an attendance award (Gubler et al., 2016)

d = 0.33
effect of positive feedback on intrinsic motivation (Deci et al., 1999)

Christiane Bradler and colleagues hired over 300 people for a three-hour data-entry job and, after two hours, handed some an unannounced thank-you card. Performance rose, most when only the best got one, and mostly among those without one. The laundry award, a $75 gift card drawn among workers with perfect attendance, was also gamed. In Deci's meta-analysis of 128 studies, tangible and expected rewards lowered intrinsic motivation.

OUR READING

Words and symbols can work. A prize tied to one measure can teach people to chase the measure, and those who already did well to feel overlooked.

Sources: Michael Kosfeld & Susanne Neckermann, American Economic Journal: Microeconomics, 2011; Christiane Bradler, Robert Dur, Susanne Neckermann & Arjan Non, Management Science, 2016; Timothy Gubler, Ian Larkin & Lamar Pierce, Organization Science, 2016 (via ScienceDaily, 2016); Edward L. Deci, Richard Koestner & Richard M. Ryan, Psychological Bulletin, 1999

Short tasks, students, one plant: the experiments show that recognition can matter; how much it will in your team, they cannot say. The −8% applies to workers whose attendance was above average before the award.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

What recognition is worth

Gallup estimated what the median business in its database could gain if twice as many employees strongly agreed that they had received recognition or praise for good work in the last seven days: one in two instead of one in four.

ESTIMATED CHANGE IF RECOGNITION DOUBLED, MEDIAN BUSINESS



The estimate rests on Gallup's meta-analysis of 456 studies in 276 organisations, covering 2.7 million employees. Gallup warns that the three effects influence each other and cannot be added up. In a team, recognition can be counted without a survey:

Three things to count

1. how many people were asked how they like to be recognised
2. who was recognised this month, and who was not
3. what for: results, help to colleagues, safety, learning

Source: Gallup & Workhuman, 2023

An estimate from correlations, made with a firm that sells recognition software. Gallup's survey item may not be reused without its consent. The list is the editors'.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The recognition card

One card, one person, once a week. Shift Pulse shows by day or week where a number improved; the card asks who made it happen and how to thank them. Once a month, look back at who was recognised.

01 Who the person or the team, role and shift

02 What exactly what they did, in one sentence, with the date

03 Why it mattered for the customer, the team, safety or a goal

04 How they like it asked? in private or before the team, spoken or written

05 Fairness check who else contributed; who has not been recognised for a while

06 Said when, by whom, how it was received

Sources: Gallup & Workhuman, 2024; Timothy Gubler, Ian Larkin & Lamar Pierce, Organization Science, 2016 (via ScienceDaily, 2016)

A practice we suggest, after the five pillars of Gallup and Workhuman and the experiments on page 6. It does not replace fair pay or promotion.

Open the tool: Shift Pulse stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-pulse/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The Human-Centered Workplace: Building Organizational Cultures That Thrive
Gallup & Workhuman, 2024
https://www.gallup.com/file/analytics/650567/Gallup-Workhuman_Human-Centered-Workplace-Report.pdf

Employee Recognition: Low Cost, High Impact
Gallup, 2016
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/236441/employee-recognition-low-cost-high-impact.aspx

OSH Pulse 2025: Occupational safety and health in the era of climate and digital change
EU-OSHA, 2025
https://osha.europa.eu/en/publications/osh-pulse-2025-occupational-safety-and-health-era-climate-and-digital-change

From Praise to Profits: The Business Case for Recognition at Work
Gallup & Workhuman, 2023
https://www.gallup.com/file/analytics/472787/Gallup-Workhuman_ROI-Report.pdf

Getting More Work for Nothing? Symbolic Awards and Worker Performance
Michael Kosfeld & Susanne Neckermann, American Economic Journal: Microeconomics, 2011
https://www.aeaweb.org/articles?id=10.1257/mic.3.3.86

Employee Recognition and Performance: A Field Experiment
Christiane Bradler, Robert Dur, Susanne Neckermann & Arjan Non, Management Science, 2016
https://doi.org/10.1287/mnsc.2015.2291

Motivational Spillovers from Awards: Crowding Out in a Multitasking Environment
Timothy Gubler, Ian Larkin & Lamar Pierce, Organization Science, 2016 · via ScienceDaily, 2016
https://doi.org/10.1287/orsc.2016.1047

A Meta-Analytic Review of Experiments Examining the Effects of Extrinsic Rewards on Intrinsic Motivation
Edward L. Deci, Richard Koestner & Richard M. Ryan, Psychological Bulletin, 1999
https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.125.6.627

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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